

How to Adapt the Pattern to Your Client

Grading the pattern to each client's measurements before cutting.

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PART 1

Before you touch the pattern

Compare measurements, don't guess.

- 1 Measure the pattern on the same lines as the client: bust, underbust, waist, high hip and hip. Without the seam allowances.
- 2 Write the pattern's measurements and the client's in a table (with the ease or reduction you're after).
- 3 Subtract: the difference on each line is what you need to add or remove.
- 4 Count the vertical seams on half the pattern: the difference is spread between them.

LINE	PATTERN (HALF)	CLIENT (HALF)	DIFFERENCE	PER SEAM
Bust				
Underbust				
Waist				
High hip				
Hip				

Work with half

Corset patterns are drafted for half the body. Divide the client's measurements by 2 before comparing. Work in cm or in inches, but don't mix them in the same table.

PART 2

Grading the circumference up or down

Spread out, never all in one place.

If half the pattern has 6 panels, there are 5 joining seams and 10 edges you can move (two per panel, except the centre front and centre back). Spread the half-difference across those 10 edges: each gets a small share and the shape of the pattern is kept. Example: if the half is missing 4 cm at the waist, that's 0.4 cm per edge (0.8 cm per seam); in inches, about 1½ in missing is roughly ⅜ in per edge (¼ in per seam).

- 1 Divide the difference on that line by the number of edges you'll move.
- 2 Mark the new point on each edge, outwards (to enlarge) or inwards (to reduce).
- 3 Join the new bust, waist and hip points with a smooth curve, following the original shape.
- 4 Don't move the centre front (busk) or centre back (eyelets) edges.

Big differences

If the difference on one line is much bigger than on the others (for example, much more hip than bust), put more on the side and hip panels and less on the front.

PART 3

Waist length

Raising or lowering the pattern's waist.

Compare the pattern's underbust-to-waist and waist-to-hip distances with the client's.

- 1 Draw a horizontal line across all the panels, between the underbust and the waist.
- 2 To lengthen: cut along that line and spread the pieces by what's missing. To shorten: overlap them.
- 3 Re-join the edges with a smooth line.
- 4 Repeat between waist and hip if needed.

Bust and cup

When the circumference is right but the shape isn't.

- **More projection:** add curve to the bust panel seams, only in the cup area, without changing the circumference.
- **Less projection:** straighten that curve.
- **Different bust separation:** move the cup seam towards the centre or towards the side.
- **Different bust height:** raise or lower the most curved part of the bust seam.

Lingerie: bras, bodysuits and knickers

The same rules, with stretch fabric.

- **Bras:** the band is fitted to the underbust (allowing for the fabric's stretch); the cup to the difference between bust and underbust.
- **Bodysuits:** the most important thing is torso length; lengthen or shorten at the waist.
- **Knickers:** the waist and leg openings depend on the elastic; back coverage on the client's preference.
- With stretch fabric, the pattern is usually smaller than the body measurement: respect the stretch the pattern indicates.

PART 6

After grading

Always a toile.

Before cutting the toile

- ☐ Seams that join are the same length.

- ☐ The notches line up.

- ☐ The curves are smooth, with no points.

- ☐ You've written the client's name and the date on the pattern.

- ☐ You've saved the graded pattern in her folder.

Next step

Choose the pattern for your next commission, fill in the table in Part 1 with your client's measurements and grade it before cutting the toile.